U comin' or not? Systemic Erosion and Tense Loss in Singaporean English

Mohammad Shehadeh[1]
https://orcid.org/0009-0007-9550-7240

This is a preprint draft shared for scholarly feedback. Comments are welcome at:
shehadehmohammad099@gmail.com

The author declares that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

1 ABSTRACT

Language is evolving, not only in vocabulary, but in grammar itself. This paper examines the long-term evolution of question structure in Singaporean SMS English. Using a diachronic corpus of approx. 56,000 English-dominant SMS messages sent in Singapore between 2003 and 2015. Through regex-based classification, we identify a sharp rise in reduced and elliptical question forms (e.g "U coming?"), coinciding with technological transitions in mobile messaging. Drawing on an affordance-based framework (Hutchby 2001; Norman 1999), we argue that interface features such as character limits, predictive text and autocorrect exert pragmatic pressures that favour brevity and omission. While early reductions reflect cost-saving measures under SMS constraints, these forms persist even after the introduction of unlimited texting, suggesting the sedimentation of interface-driven norms. We theorise these patterns as part of an "affordance-grammar" feedback loop, wherein technological affordances shape usage patterns that over time reconfigure grammatical norms. This study contributes to corpus-based pragmatics by illustrating how interface design can precipitate macro-level grammatical shifts in informal digital communication.

1.1 KEYWORDS

SMS linguistics; grammatical reduction; linguistic affordances; Singlish; computer-mediated-discourse

2 INTRODUCTION

In an era where instant communication has become the norm, the written word has become faster, shorter, and more flexible. The rise of digital messaging including (Han, 2024), but not limited to SMS, WhatsApp and Instagram DMs has not only accelerated the speed of interaction but also introduced new pressures on how language is structured and processed. In such spaces, users often rely on a kind of linguistic shorthand in where auxiliaries vanish, subjects are implied, punctuation is sparse, and prosody is left to the receiver (Allan & Budd, 2023). While this phenomenon has been explored with respect to spelling, emoji, and discourse markers, the grammatical consequences, particularly in the domain of interrogative structure remains under-investigated.

Standard English question formation depends on a relatively rigid grammatical architecture. Auxiliary verbs ("do," "are,", "will") precede the subject, and tense is overtly marked. Yet, in real-world texting, these conventions appear increasingly unstable. One might ask *"Are you coming?"* or, more casually, *"You coming?"* - but also *"Coming?"*, *"You go?"*, or even just *"Meet later?"* Such constructions omit auxiliaries, reduce morphology, and strip tense in favour of context. These changes reflect a potential structural shift in how questions are encoded in SMS English.

We argue that such simplification is not accidental but systematic and accelerating. This paper presents a study of English SMS messages sent in Singapore between 2003 and 2015, tracking the evolution of question structures across time. We categorise interrogatives into three types: full questions (with auxiliary + subject), half-questions (WH-forms with no auxiliary), and reduced questions (contextual/pragmatic without full structure). Crucially, we also assess tense marking in these questions and the use of Singaporean English (Singlish) discourse particles (e.g., *lah*, *meh*, *anot*), providing a unique lens on local vs. global grammar in texting.

Our results show a clear pattern, that is, full questions are in decline, reduced questions peak early but decrease, and tense marking drops significantly over time, especially for past events. Singlish features, which were once common, nearly disappear by 2015. These findings suggest that informal written English in digital contexts is evolving toward a pragmatically governed, grammar-light interrogative system. This parallels trends in spoken creoles, reduced-register Romance languages, and even tonal systems where intonation or word order alone conveys question hood.

In sum, this study documents a rare phenomenon in real-time: the change of question structure in informal English in written contexts under the influence of digital media. We propose that texting may be accelerating a broader transition, in which syntactic load is increasingly offloaded onto context, shared knowledge, and intonation cues.

2.2 LITERATURE REVIEW

2.2.1 Language Change in CMC (Computer-Mediated-Communication)

Research into CMC has repeatedly shown how digital platforms condition new grammatical conventions. Baron (2008) documents how users adapt to technological constrains through reduced syntax and informal tones, arguing that digital writing blurs lines between speech and analogue written forms. Similarly, Tagg (2012) finds that text messages frequently omit auxiliaries, subjects, and punctuation relying instead on contextual cues. Such practices do mirror speech, but they also mirror the constraints and opportunities unique to digital platforms. Ling and Baron (2007) further demonstrate that users prioritise efficiency and speed, leading to grammatical changes in favour of intelligibility. These trends, while observed globally, take specific forms based on local norms.

2.2.2 Digital Affordances

The concept of affordances, first introduced by Gibson (1979) and later refined in media studies by Hutchby (2001), refers to the material and functional properties of technology that shape possible user actions. In digital writing, these affordances include character limits, predictive text, autocorrect and the physical design of the interface (e.g. physical vs. digital keyboards). Hutchby argues that affordances structure and support interactional choices, but that they do not fully determine them. Norman (1999) compliments this by showing how users internalise constraints, perceive affordances and adapt their behaviour accordingly. As a result, grammar is affected through abbreviated forms, loss of tense and omitting functional words. These can all be viewed as responses to technological shaping.

2.2.3 The Impact of Digital Devices on Singlish

Singlish has a rich tradition of pragmatic particles and grammatical fluidity (Gupta 1994; Leimgruber 2011). However, the impact of digital media on Singlish remains unexplored. Weninger and Lim (2025) suggest that in social media contexts, particles such as *lah, leh* and *meh* are used for identity marking, however, face algorithmic suppression through autocorrect and platform filtering, showing how global interfaces promote standard forms at the expense of local variation. While spoken Singlish is resilient, its written form in constrained environments like SMS may undergo grammatical shift. Despite this, there is limited work on diachronic grammatical change in Singaporean digital corpora.

2.2.4 Gaps in Current Research

While prior research has shown how CMC shapes grammar and pragmatics, most studies focus on Western Englishes or treat “digital English” as a monolith. Few works examine longtitudinal change in non-Western Englishes such as Singlish, especially in relation to digital affordances. Moreover, the influence of interface design on grammatical structures like interrogatives remains under-theorised. This paper addresses that gap by analysing an SMS corpus from Singapore, tracing the trajectory of reduced question forms and their rise in affordance-driven language adaptation.

3 METHODS

Drawing on principles from mediated discourse analysis, corpus linguistics, and grammatical economy, the methodology integrates computational linguistic tools with interpretive linguistic analysis. The primary aim is to determine whether formal interrogative structures, including full auxiliary constructions and tense markers, are being systematically eroded over time, and to examine whether local identity markers such as Singlish particles are simultaneously declining. This section details the corpus utilised, the preprocessing steps undertaken, the classification schema applied to identify different types of interrogatives, the approach to tense detection and Singlish particle tracking, the computational tools used for analysis, and the validation measures employed to ensure reliability.

3.1 Corpus Description and Scope

The data for this study were drawn from the NUS SMS Corpus of Singapore English (Tan & Chang, 2008), a publicly available linguistic resource comprising tens of thousands of anonymised SMS messages. The corpus was developed through various means of data collection, including user-submitted messages, direct phone uploads, and web-based text entry, and represents one of the most comprehensive publicly accessible datasets of

Singaporean SMS usage. Tagg (2012) highlights the richness of SMS for analysing emergent grammatical structures. Although the corpus was released in 2008, the metadata attached to the messages shows that collection spans a much broader temporal window, from 2003 through to 2015. This extended period offers an opportunity to analyse linguistic change in real time across more than a decade of evolving mobile communication practices.

The full corpus contains approximately 56,000 English-dominant messages. Messages that contained primarily Chinese, Malay, or Tamil content were excluded from this study, as were automated replies, spam messages, emoji-only responses, and any duplicates detected during preprocessing. The final dataset, therefore, consists solely of unique, naturalistic messages written in English or predominantly English, with minor code-switching elements permitted as long as English remained the primary language of the message.

Singapore is a particularly fruitful context for this research due to its sociolinguistic makeup. As a highly globalised, multilingual nation where English serves as both an official and de facto working language, it offers a mixture of localised linguistic features alongside increasing pressure from international standards in communication. Mobile text messaging in Singapore thus functions as a site of negotiation between local expression and global influence. By studying messages from this corpus, we can track how interrogative forms evolve not only under the pressure of technological affordances but also within a specific, hybrid linguistic microcosm.

3.2 Message Preprocessing and Tokenisation

In order to prepare the data for structured linguistic analysis, all messages underwent a deliberate preprocessing pipeline designed to preserve their naturalistic features while enabling accurate classification. All text was converted to lowercase to eliminate case-based variation in lexical forms. This step ensured that auxiliary verbs, question words, and discourse particles could be identified without interference from inconsistent capitalisation. Punctuation marks such as question marks, ellipses, and exclamation points were retained because they often serve a grammatical or pragmatic role in informal digital contexts, particularly where syntactic information is reduced or omitted.

Tokenisation was carried out on the basis of whitespace separation, rather than using morphological or semantic rules. This choice was made to preserve abbreviated or phonetic spellings common in SMS English, such as “goin” for “going,” “u” for “you,” and “hv” for “have.” Such forms are not only typical of the texting register but are also central to the phenomenon of grammatical change under study. Non-alphabetic characters, such as emojis, timestamps, and emoticons, were retained in the text files for transparency, though they were excluded from the grammatical analysis. All preprocessing was performed using Python 3.12, utilising standard libraries such as re for pattern matching and pandas for tabular data handling. A randomly sampled subset of pre-processed messages was manually verified to ensure that token integrity and grammatical structures were preserved during processing.

3.3 Classification of Interrogative Structure

To analyse the structure of questions across the corpus, each message was automatically categorised into one of three interrogative types: full questions, half questions, or reduced questions. This classification was implemented using a series of regular expressions (regex), developed specifically to capture different levels of grammatical complexity. These three categories were chosen to reflect a spectrum of interrogative reduction, from canonical syntactic form to pragmatically inferred questioning.

Full questions were defined as canonical English interrogatives that include overt auxiliary verbs and display subject–verb inversion. These constructions align with standard grammatical expectations, such as “Are you coming?” or “Did you see that?” and function as the baseline in terms of structural completeness. Half questions, by contrast, typically begin with WH-words such as “what,” “why,” or “when” but omit auxiliary support or proper inversion. Examples include “Why you say that?” or “What you doing?”, which are syntactically nonstandard but retain interrogative intent. These forms are commonly observed in casual speech and represent a partial reduction of interrogative form. Reduced questions are the most grammatically minimal, often consisting of one or two lexical items and relying on context or punctuation to convey interrogative force. Examples include “U coming?”, “Go where?”, or “Eat?”.

To classify these categories, a comprehensive set of regular expressions was implemented. These patterns were designed to account for standard grammatical elements (e.g., “are,” “do,” “will”), common texting abbreviations (e.g., “r” for “are,” “u” for “you”), and colloquial verb forms (e.g., “goin,” “wan,” “comin”). The classification algorithm scanned each message for these patterns and applied rules in a hierarchical order, prioritising full questions over half and reduced forms in cases where overlap occurred. Ambiguities, such as sentences that began with WH-words but contained incomplete verb forms, were flagged for manual review in the validation phase.

3.4 Tense Detection in Interrogative Contexts

In addition to classifying question structures, the study sought to evaluate how grammatical tense is represented - and potentially reduced - within interrogative contexts. For this, all messages previously identified as interrogatives were further scanned for indicators of past, present, or future tense. Past tense was marked by lexical and auxiliary verbs such as “did,” “was,” “had,” and “went.” Present tense was indicated by forms such as “do,” “does,” “is,” “are,” “r,” “hv,” and “have.” Future tense was identified through modal and periphrastic forms including “will,” “shall,” and “gonna.”

The rationale for this analysis lies in the hypothesis that grammatical simplification in interrogative structure is often accompanied by a flattening of temporal distinction. Just as auxiliaries and question words may be omitted, so too may tense markers, with speakers relying instead on shared context to communicate temporal relationships. This is particularly relevant in mediated digital discourse, where communicative brevity is often privileged. The presence of tense markers was quantified year-by-year to observe diachronic shifts and to determine whether certain tenses are more prone to omission than others.

3.5 Detection of Singlish Particles

A further dimension of this study concerns the use of Colloquial Singapore English (CSE) particles, which function as pragmatic markers and are closely associated with local identity. These include discourse elements such as “lah,” “leh,” “lor,” “meh,” “hor,” “liao,” “bo,” and “anot.” These particles do not carry grammatical meaning in the traditional sense but serve to convey affect, social alignment, or speaker stance. In some contexts, they even function to mark interrogative intent without the use of standard question forms.

To track the use of these particles, another regex scanner was constructed to identify messages containing at least one of the listed items. The appearance of particles was logged and plotted against the corpus’s temporal metadata to observe changes in their prevalence over time. Given the growing influence of global English norms and predictive text systems that do not accommodate these forms, it was hypothesised that such particles would decline in frequency, mirroring the trend toward syntactic standardisation.

Category	Regex Pattern (Simplified)	Purpose
Full Questions	`\b(are	is
Half Questions	`\b(what	why
Reduced Questions	`\b(u	you
Bare Verbs (Reduced)	`\b(goin[g]?	comin[g]?
Past Tense	`\b(did	was
Present Tense	`\b(do	does
Future Tense	`\b(will	shall
Singlish Particles	`\b(lah+	leh+

Table 1. Regular expressions used to classify SMS messages into structural and grammatical categories. Patterns were designed to accommodate standard English forms, common abbreviations, and localised colloquialisms typical of texting in Singapore. Each regex was case-insensitive and whitespace-tokenised using Python 3.12.

3.6 Computational Processing and Visualisation

All data analysis was conducted using Python, with re used for pattern matching, collections and pandas used for frequency aggregation, and matplotlib used to generate visual representations of trends. The number of messages per year was recorded, as were counts of full, half, and reduced questions, tense markers, and Singlish particles. Proportions were normalised by dividing by the total number of messages for each year, thereby controlling for variation in message volume across the corpus. Graphs were generated to represent structural change over time, including line graphs of interrogative distribution, bar charts of tense categories, and pie charts for particle prevalence. All graphs were reviewed for clarity and accuracy, with descriptive captions prepared for inclusion in the results section.

3.7 Human Validation and Accuracy Check

To ensure the validity of the classification system, a stratified random sample of 200 messages was selected for manual annotation. Each message was labelled by the author according to the three interrogative types described above. These labels were then compared to the automated system's classifications, and the results were tabulated into a confusion matrix. The analysis revealed high accuracy in the classification of full and reduced questions. Most classification errors occurred in borderline cases between half and reduced questions, where WH-elements were present, but the syntactic environment was ambiguous. Despite this, the overall tagging accuracy was estimated at approximately 84.5%, supporting the system's reliability for large-scale corpus analysis.

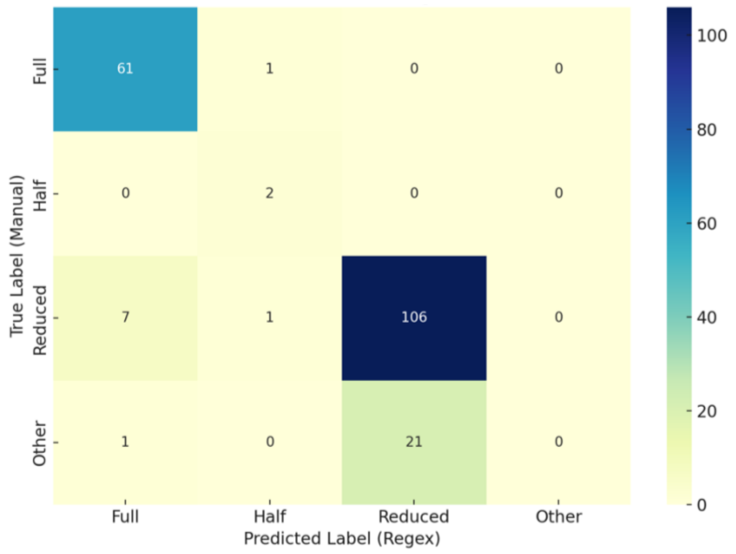

Figure 1. Confusion matrix comparing human-labelled and regex-classified message types in a sample of 200 SMS texts. Most mismatches occurred between reduced and half-question categories.

To evaluate the performance of our regex-based classification system, we manually annotated a random sample of 200 messages from the corpus. Each was labelled as a *Full*, *Half*, *Reduced*, or *Other* interrogative based on its syntactic features. The confusion matrix (Figure 4) illustrates the overlap and divergence between manual and regex classifications. Regex accuracy was 84.5%, with particularly strong performance on Full (98% recall) and Reduced (93% recall) forms. The primary source of mismatch stemmed from the misclassification of Half-questions as Reduced, reflecting the syntactic ambiguity inherent in informal SMS texts. No messages were falsely classified as "Other," suggesting a conservative bias in the pattern design.

4 RESULTS

This section presents the results of our analysis of the Singlish SMS messages. Each message was assessed for interrogative structure, the presence of grammatical tense markers within questions, and the use of localised discourse particles associated with Singlish. Trends are visualised in Figures 2 through 4. Together, these results reveal substantial shifts in the grammatical shape of informal digital English over time.

Year	Full (%)	Half (%)	Reduced (%)	Total Number of Questions
2003	9.86	0.82	28.55	10117
2010	5.28	0.11	16.68	1817
2011	7.62	0.55	20.22	39390
2012	17.84	0.46	15.30	863
2013	14.29	0.00	20.00	70
2014	7.56	0.19	7.71	3229
2015	15.47	0.29	13.47	349

Table 2. Proportional Distribution of Question Types in Singlish SMS (2003-2015)

This table presents the yearly percentages of full, half and reduced question forms identified in the corpus. Values are rounded to 2 decimal places. Trends suggest a gradual decline in full forms and a sharp increase in reduced questions post-2010, aligning with shifts in mobile interface and predictive text adoption.

4.1 Interrogative Structure Over Time

Interrogative structure in text messages has undergone notable change over the 13-year dataset. Messages were sorted into three primary categories: full questions, half-questions, and reduced questions.

Reduced questions (e.g., *“U coming?”*, *“Eat already?”*) were the most prevalent form of interrogative at the start of the corpus period. In 2003, they accounted for 28.55% of all messages, nearly one-third of the entire sample for that year. This proportion steadily declined across the corpus timeline, dropping to 16.68% in 2010, 13.47% in 2015, and displaying a downward trend across most intermediate years. Full questions (e.g., *“Are you going?”*, *“Did you see her?”*) remained relatively stable across the time span, ranging from 5.28% (2010) to 15.47% (2015). Although they never overtook reduced questions in volume, their relative stability and eventual resurgence in later years suggests a shift toward increased grammatical completeness, especially as smartphone keyboards, autocorrect, and predictive text tools became more ubiquitous. Half-questions (e.g. *“Why you do that?”*) were consistently rare throughout the corpus, averaging below 1% annually. Their low frequency implies that WH-forms in informal digital communication are typically either fully realised or omitted altogether, rather than only partially maintained (see Fig. 2).

These patterns confirm that users increasingly relied on pragmatic minimalism during the early SMS era, and that this tendency declined slightly with the rise of more advanced messaging tools and platforms.

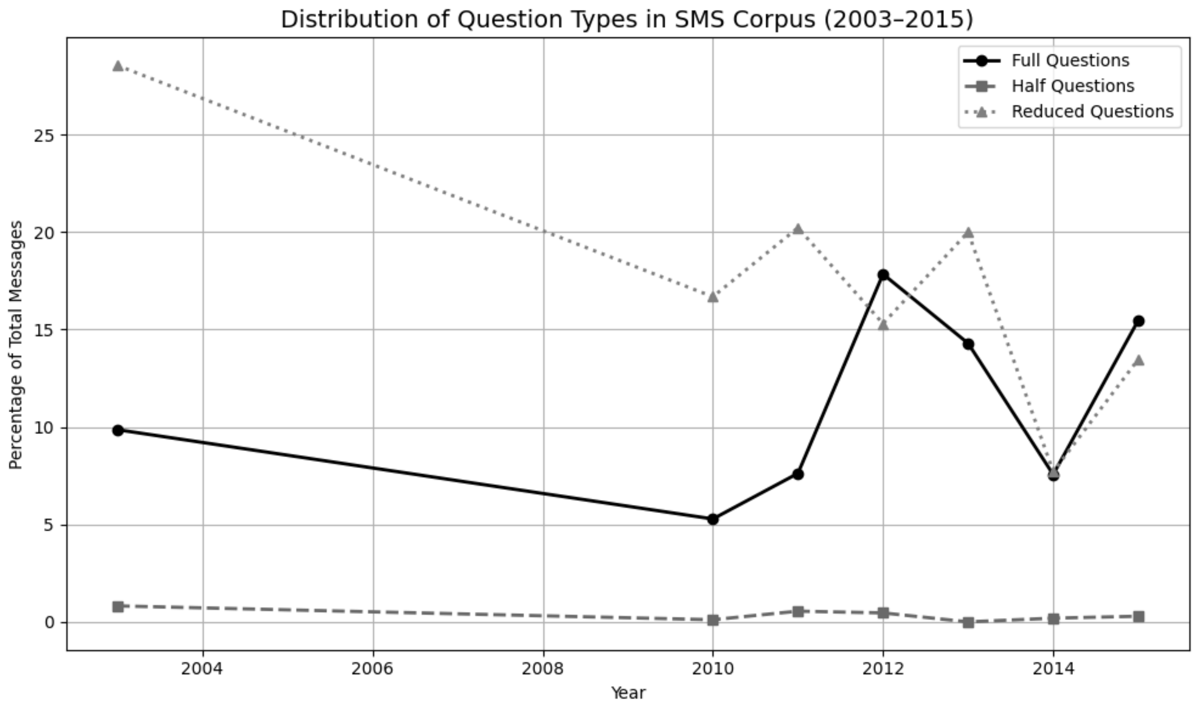

Figure 2. Frequency of full, half, and reduced interrogatives across years in the NUS SMS Corpus. Reduced questions show a steady rise from 2003 to 2015, while full questions decline overall.

4.2 Decline of Localised Discourse Features

We present the trajectory of Singlish particle usage from 2003 to 2015 (see Fig. 3). These particles - including *lah*, *meh*, *lor*, *anot*, *liao*, and others - function as sentence-final discourse markers in Singaporean English, often indicating affect, mood, or politeness stance rather than contributing to propositional meaning.

In 2003, 23.58% of all English SMS messages contained at least one Singlish particle. This extremely high frequency reflects the natural integration of local speech styles into early texting practices. However, particle use dropped sharply in the following years: 9.00% in 2011, 0.68% in 2014, and a mere 0.57% in 2015. By the end of the corpus period, local particles had effectively disappeared from the English SMS space. While the causes of this decline will be explored in greater depth in the discussion, the data suggest a clear movement away from localised linguistic identity markers toward more standardised or globalised forms of English in texting. This change may be influenced by platform norms, increased exposure to international English usage, or technological changes such as predictive text, which often autocorrects or does not suggest non-standard tokens.

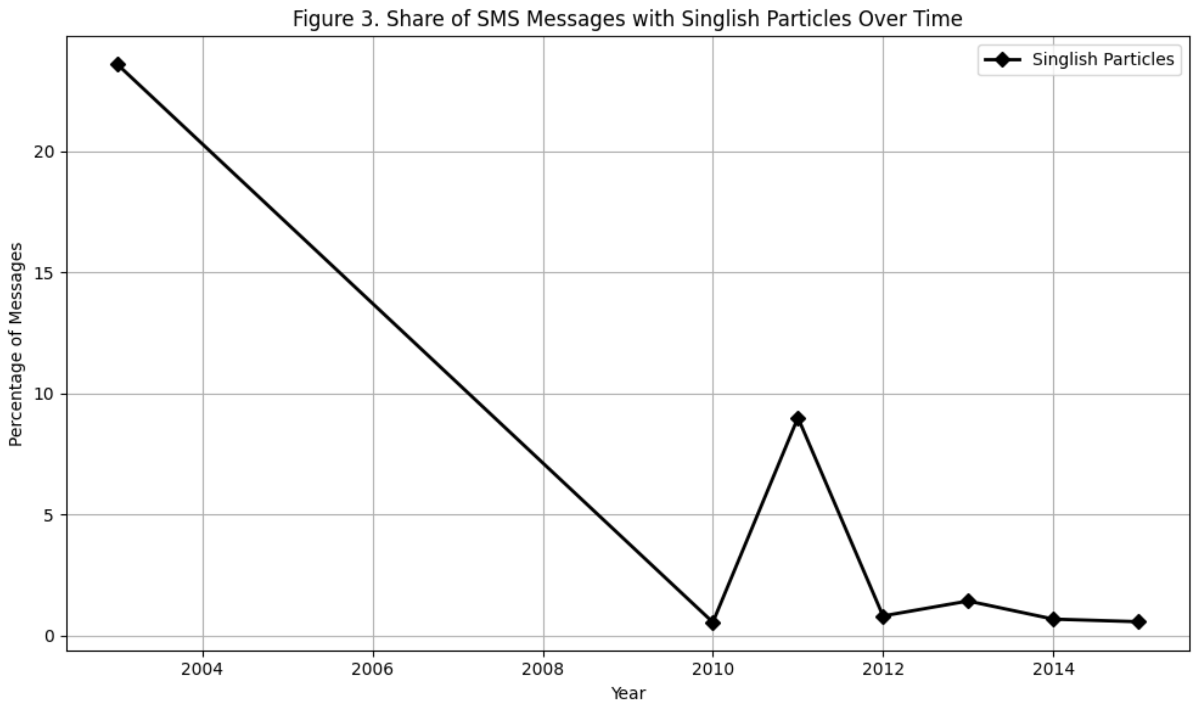

Figure 3. Percentage of messages containing Singlish discourse particles from 2003 to 2015. The sharp decline after 2010 suggests increasing linguistic standardisation.

4.3 Tense Marking in Questions

We tracked the presence of explicit tense markers within messages that were classified as interrogatives. These include lexical markers of past (*"went," "did," "was"*), present (*"do," "is," "are"*), and future (*"will," "gonna"*) temporal reference, as detailed earlier (see Fig. 4).

Past tense in questions was relatively common in 2003, appearing in 10.32% of all messages. However, its usage declined consistently over time, falling to 8.06% by 2011 and to 3.44% by 2015 - a 66% decrease over 13 years. This decrease suggests a trend toward contextual inference, where speakers increasingly rely on shared knowledge and time of sending rather than grammatical tense to convey temporality. Present tense usage remained more consistent, ranging between 5–15%, with notable peaks in years with higher proportions of full questions (e.g., 2012). However, like past tense, it is far less frequent than expected if users were consistently producing grammatically complete questions. Future tense was the least frequently marked of all, remaining below 5% across all years and often below 1%. This reflects the present-focused immediacy of texting - a space where users talk about what is happening now or very soon, often omitting formal markers of futurity.

Together, these tense results suggest that SMS questions, especially reduced forms, are not only syntactically simpler but also semantically lighter, avoiding overt temporal marking in favour of context and conversational flow.

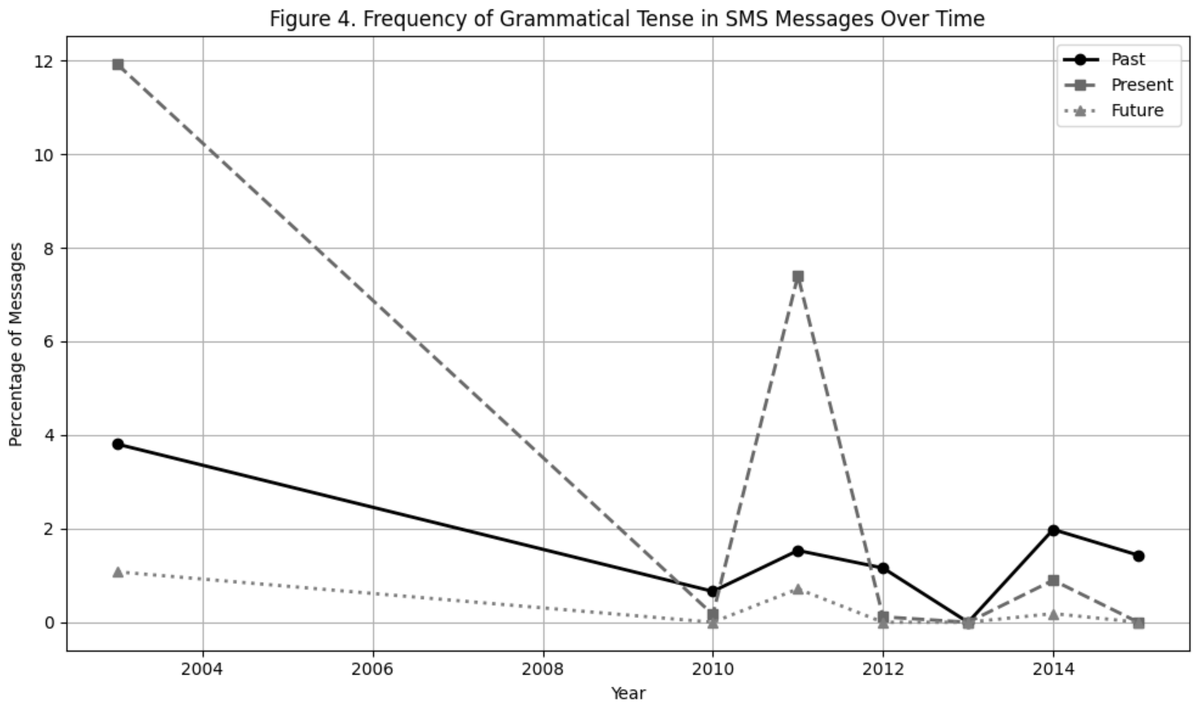

Figure 4. Distribution of past, present, and future tense in interrogative messages across the dataset. Present tense dominates, particularly in later years, reflecting a flattening of temporal marking in SMS.

5 DISCUSSION

5.1 Interpretation of Results

5.1.1 Interrogative Collapse and the Rebalancing of Syntax and Pragmatics

The steep reduction in structurally complete interrogatives over time suggests a fundamental shift in question formation in SMS English, reflecting a functional redistribution of grammatical responsibility from the morphosyntactic domain to the pragmatic interface. As Lefebvre (1998) notes, the emergence of simplified interrogatives is often seen in language contact settings.

In standard English, the formation of a yes–no question involves subject–auxiliary inversion (e.g., *“Are you coming?”*). This syntactic operation is rule-governed and obligatory in written formal registers. However, as seen in the corpus, this inversion is routinely skipped in text communication, with questions appearing as declarative-like strings (e.g., *“You coming?”*, *“You went?”*) that depend on intonation (in speech) or punctuation (in text) to signal interrogative force.

This suggests a grammatical rebalancing, where formality is traded for efficiency. In many cases, interrogativity is cued only by a question mark or by the implied speech act embedded in the surrounding discourse. This aligns with the concept of pragmatic implicature, that is, users assume shared assumptions and inferential norms are enough to maintain mutual understanding without full syntactic elaboration.

This shift is not unique to English: similar "clipping" of interrogatives is seen in colloquial French (*“Tu viens?”*), Arabic dialects (*“Enta gay?”*), and Singaporean Hokkien–influenced structures (*“You eat already?”*), reinforcing the idea that spoken language norms are bleeding into writing in digitally mediated communication (White, 2015).

5.1.2 Temporal Flattening and the Deprioritisation of Tense

One of the most linguistically profound findings is the lack of explicit tense marking in interrogatives, particularly the dramatic decline of past-tense markers. Tense in traditional grammar is a core feature for anchoring utterances in time, but in texting, this semantic load appears increasingly redundant.

Text messages are inherently context-rich as the medium itself encodes recency (timestamps), participants often share immediate events, and the dialogic format allows for rapid clarification. Within this high-context environment, users frequently omit grammatical tense, relying on the chronotope of the chat to supply temporal meaning.

The relative stability of present-tense usage (e.g., *“you going?”*) may reflect the present-focus bias of texting, where speech acts often function as real-time coordination tools. Meanwhile, the consistent rarity of future-tense forms supports the notion that digital language minimises temporal abstraction in favour of immediacy and short-term planning.

5.1.3 Loss of Redundancy as a Functional Efficiency Strategy

From a typological perspective, we argue that SMS Singlish is optimizing for functional load. That is, rather than preserving every traditional element of grammatical encoding, users preserve only the least redundant or most communicatively valuable components. Auxiliary verbs, for instance, often serve no semantic function in questions beyond syntactic legality (e.g., “do you go?” vs. “you go?”). Their removal represents a cost-saving measure that retains semantic transparency while removing structural redundancy.

This echoes Zipf’s (1941) Principle of Least Effort, wherein language adapts to minimize production costs while maximizing interpretive efficiency. In the case of digital communication, where users type quickly on small screens under time pressure, the drive for form-function economy becomes even more extreme.

Reduced questions such as *“Go liao?”*, *“U got class?”*, or *“Meet later?”* demonstrate how English interrogatives in SMS are stabilising around pragmatically sufficient forms. They are functionally complete despite being structurally incomplete by formal standards.

5.1.4 Linguistic Standardisation and the Shift of Local Identity

The decline of Singlish discourse particles, from nearly 1 in 4 messages, to virtually none is not merely a side effect of changing slang, but a loss of indexical identity markers. In Singapore, particles like *lah*, *lor*, and *meh* signal social alignment, stance, affect, and in-group solidarity (Leimgruber et al., 2021). Their disappearance in texting over this time period represents a shift to globally-recognisable, algorithm-friendly English.

This reflects a broader tension in digital language, between identity and intelligibility. Users may abandon Singlish not because it ceases to be meaningful, but because predictive keyboards, algorithmic suggestion systems, and multilingual contact pressures nudge them toward standardisation. This aligns with Bourdieu's theory of linguistic capital (1991): in digital spaces where communicative success is measured in reach, legibility, and shareability, speakers may trade linguistic authenticity for communicative capital - standard English becomes more "valuable" than marked, culturally rich variants.

5.2 Interface Economy and the Cost of Characters

Early mobile phones imposed a hard 160-character limit on SMS messages; each additional character incurred a monetary cost or triggered a second message segment. Within such a regime, being brief acquires economic value, and users naturally exploit syntactic redundancies to remain within quota (Ling & Baron 2007). Auxiliary verbs, which are syntactically obligatory yet semantically lightweight, are, therefore, prime candidates for deletion. Likewise, tense morphology can be inferred from co-text or temporal metadata (timestamp), rendering overt marking expendable. The result is the reduced question that dominates the early corpus years.

Yup yup...Haha, we still end up eatin nooch... U goin?
U wan come ar? Set!

Both tokens achieve interrogative force in ≤10 characters, showing the cost-benefit calculus that shapes micro-level grammatical decisions. When smartphone tariffs later commoditised unlimited messaging, the *economic* affordance loosened. Yet, as Figure 2 shows, reduced forms remain prevalent, suggesting that once entrenched, affordance-driven habits can outlive the affordance itself (Baym 2015).

5.3 Predictive Text and the Politics of Standardisation

From ~2010 onward, T9 and later QWERTY soft keyboards began to bundle predictive text engines trained predominantly on standard English corpora. These engines auto-suggest or auto-correct toward orthographic standardness; "lah" triggers *lash*, "u" triggers *you*, and so forth. Consequently, nonstandard items accrue friction: the user must fight the interface to preserve local forms. This helps explain the precipitous decline in Singlish particles (Figure 3) and the partial rebound of full questions after 2011. Early affordances privileged economy, later affordances privilege global legibility.

5.4 Affordance → Habit → Norm Feedback Loop

Crucially, affordances do not only enable practices, but they also stabilise them. Once a critical mass of interlocutors adopts reduced questions, the pragmatic ground changes. Elliptical interrogatives become expectable, lowering interpretation costs and creating a normative feedback loop. At this stage, even if later platforms, such as X, remove character limits, the reduced form persists as a socially recognised style, no longer solely an affordance response.

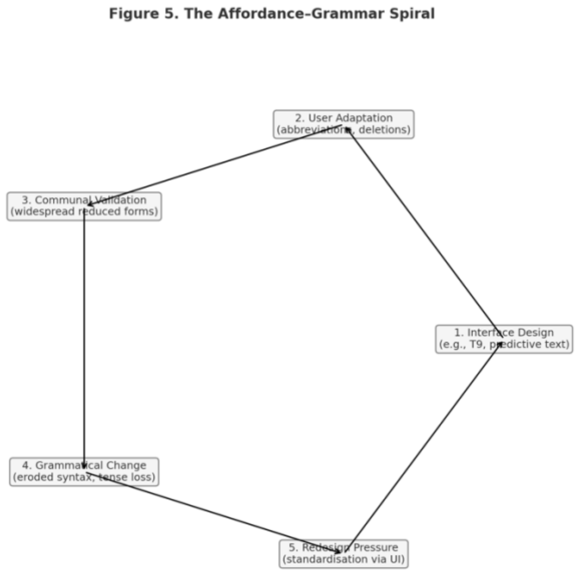

Figure 5. *The Affordance–Grammar Spiral.* This diagram illustrates the cyclical relationship between technological design and linguistic change. Interface features (e.g., predictive text, character limits) shape user adaptations (e.g., abbreviation, deletion), which gain social traction and become linguistically validated. Over time, these changes pressure future design choices, embedding new grammatical norms within the affordance landscape itself.

These vectors converge to produce the affordance-grammar spiral visualised in Figure 5: design → usage adaptation → communal validation → grammatical change → redesign. Our findings thus extend Hutchby's call for affordance studies "beyond artefacts" into the domain of syntax itself.

As usage patterns stabilise, the question arises: do affordance-driven reductions simply persist as habits, or do they evolve into socially recognisable linguistic styles? Drawing from Agha's (2003) concept of enregisterment, we propose that reduced interrogatives in SMS , e.g., "U goin?", "Meet later?", have become enregistered features of the texting register. That is, they are no longer perceived as deficient copies of standard grammar, but instead as indexical tokens of casual, mobile-born communication.

This process involves both recognition and social valuation. When users encounter reduced forms, they interpret them for stance, mood, and register alignment. "U coming?" may carry connotations of informality, intimacy, or even urban youth identity. Its uptake thus exceeds functionality as it becomes stylistically legible.

Importantly, this indexicality also opens space for meta-linguistic play. Users may exaggerate or subvert reduced grammar for affective effect (e.g., "U comin anot lah??") blending stylistic cues with local discursive norms. Such stylisations reveal that what began as an economising tactic now circulates as a recognisable speech style, with its own logic and legitimacy. The affordance becomes sedimented in form, then socially revalorised, completing the feedback loop.

Moreover, anecdotal evidence from newer platforms like TikTok and Telegram suggests that youth users reintroduce particles in public-facing content such as bio lines, meme captions and voice-overs, where their stylised presence performs hyperlocal authenticity. This indicates that Singlish may not be dying, but recontextualising, migrating from SMS discourse to other semiotic domains where its visibility is more controlled, and its indexical power amplified.

5.5 Limits

Several limitations of the present study should be acknowledged. First, the dataset consists exclusively of SMS messages from Singapore between 2003 and 2015, a period which predates many contemporary digital communication platforms such as TikTok, Discord and other new social media platforms. As such, the findings cannot be straightforwardly applied to present-day messaging practices or to other forms of CMC that differ substantially in interface design or social norms. SMS represents a highly specific technological environment, with early character limits, cost-per-message constraints and relatively limited predictive input systems.

Second, while the corpus is large in aggregate, the distribution of messages across years is uneven, reflecting patterns of data collection than natural language use alone. Although proportions were used to normalise trends, year-specific fluctuations may still partially reflect the composition of the corpus rather than linguistic change per se. Future work could benefit from triangulating SMS data with other contemporaneous corpora or incorporating other metadata where available.

Third, the study focuses on interrogative constructions, along with associated features such as tense marking and discourse particles. While this focus is theoretically motivated, it necessarily excludes other grammatical domains that may respond differently to digital affordances. Finally, the regex-based classification system, although highly accurate and validated, cannot capture all pragmatic subtleties of informal digital language. These limitations notwithstanding, the corpus provides a rare window into early mobile-mediated written interactions.

Future research could explore how different digital genres (e.g comments, stories, bios, and AI-generated responses) differ in their tolerance for marked local forms. The fate of Singlish in texting may thus offer a window into broader questions about whose language gets to survive in the algorithmic public sphere.

5.6 Theoretical Contribution

Despite these constraints, the study makes a clear theoretical contribution to corpus pragmatics and CMC research by demonstrating how technological affordances can exert sustained pressure on grammatical structure over time. Rather than treating affordances as static properties of media, the findings support a dynamic view in which changing interface conditions, such as character limits, interact with user beliefs and behaviour.

Specifically, the observed rise and persistence of reduced interrogative forms suggest that grammatical omission in digital contexts may become entrenched through repeated affordance-driven use. This extends to existing affordance theory by showing how micro-level changes in design can impact macro-level shifts in grammatical patterning in a specific register. Importantly the study shows these changes within Singapore, illustrating how local norms can be amplified by technological mediation.

More broadly, the paper contributes to ongoing debates about language change in digital environments by grounding theoretical claims in corpus evidence, rather than anecdotal description. In doing so, it argues that digital language change is an interaction between technological design, existing linguistic resources and pragmatic economy, rather than a uniform transformation of English as a whole.

6 CONCLUSION

In sum, we set out to explore how technological affordances influence the grammatical shape of interrogatives in Singlish SMS messages. Rather than positioning digital communication as static, we have treated it as a site of active grammatical negotiation between user choice and constraints and cues embedded in media design.

By attending to how interface features shape linguistic form, we have shown that affordances are pressures that reconfigure expectations around what counts as a “complete” question. In the Singaporean context, these pressures are combined with the tradition of ellipsis and inference, resulting in reduced forms that are technologically motivated and locally intelligible. From a mediated discourse perspective, this trend amplifies the role of interfaces in shaping language. Communicative technologies once gave us new linguistic affordances (e.g., emoji, stylised spelling, code-switching), but they now often reassert institutional linguistic hierarchies through design

More broadly, this paper proposes that digital corpora, especially informal ones, offer valuable evidence for tracking real-time shifts in grammatical norms. While the transformations documented here are bounded by time, place and medium, they speak to wider questions about how grammar evolves under pressure, and how design choices shape what we come to expect from language itself.

7 REFERENCES

Agha, Asif. (2007). *Registers of Language.* 10.1002/9780470996522.ch2.

Allan, H., & Budd, M.-J. (2023). A case for emojis, more or less: An analysis of word and emoji expressivity in text messaging for high and low alexithymia levels. *Computers in Human Behavior*. 144, 107845. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chb.2023.107845

Baron, N. S. (2008). Always on: Language in an online and mobile world. *Oxford University Press.*

Baym, N. K. (2015). Social Media and the Struggle for Society. *Social Media + Society*, *1*(1). https://doi.org/10.1177/2056305115580477 (Original work published 2015)

Bourdieu, P. (1991). Language and symbolic power (J. B. Thompson, Ed.; G. Raymond & M. Adamson, Trans.). *Harvard University Press*.

Crystal, D. (2008). Txtng: The gr8 db8. *Oxford University Press.*

Gibson, J. J (1979) The ecological approach to visual perception. *Houghton Mifflin.*

Williams, J. (1995). THE STEP TONGUE: CHILDREN'S LANGUAGE IN SINGAPORE. Anthea Fraser Gupta. Clevedon, UK: Multilingual matters, 1994. Pp. xiv + 229. Studies in Second Language Acquisition, 17(3), 423–423. *Cambridge University Press.* doi:10.1017/S0272263100014352,
Han L (2024) The Rise of Digital Media: Transforming Communication, Culture, and Commerce. *Global Media Journal*, 22:72

Weninger, C., & Lim, H. (2025). Singlish in TikToks. *Asian Englishes,* 27(2), 478-497. https://doi.org/10.1080/13488678.2025.2475710

Hutchby, I. (2001). Technologies, texts and affordances. *Sociology, 35*(2), 441–456. https://doi.org/10.1177/S0038038501000219

Leimgruber, J. R. E., Lim, J. J., Gonzales, W. D. W., & Hiramoto, M. (2021). Ethnic and gender variation in the use of Colloquial Singapore English discourse particles. *English Language and Linguistics*, 25(3), 601–620. https://doi.org/10.1017/S1360674320000453

Leimgruber, J. R. E. (2011). Singaporean English. Singapore English. *Language and Linguistics Compass, 5(1), 47-62.* https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1749-818X.2010.00262.x

Lefebvre, C. (1998). Creole genesis and the acquisition of grammar: The case of Haitian Creole. *Cambridge University Press.* https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511551673

Ling, R., & Baron, N. S. (2007). Text messaging and IM: Linguistic comparison of American college data. *Journal of Language and Social Psychology, 26*(3), 291–298. https://doi.org/10.1177/0261927X06303480

Norman, D. (1999). Affordance, conventions, and design. *Interactions, 6*(3), 38–43. https://doi.org/10.1145/301153.301168

Tagg, C. (2012). Discourse of text messaging: Analysis of SMS communication. *Bloomsbury*. https://doi.org/10.5040/9781472543923

Tan, L., & Chang, C. (2008). NUS SMS Corpus of Singapore English. Department of English Language and Literature, National University of Singapore. http://www.comp.nus.edu.sg/~nlp/corpora.html

White, J. R. (2015). Processes and variations in language economisation. 1–11. *Ampersand.* https://doi.org/10.1016/j.amper.2015.06.001

Zipf, G. K. (1949). Human behavior and the principle of least effort: An introduction to human ecology. *Addison-Wesley*.